

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Exodus

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What does it mean to be in a relationship with God, the ultimate being in the universe? How does one establish that relationship? What is that relationship like, and what does it take to stay in it? These are questions that people around the world have been asking since the beginning of time. The book of Exodus provided the ancient Israelites with answers to such questions, revealing not only what was required of them in a relationship with God, but also what God had graciously done to make that relationship possible.

Setting

The events of Exodus happened sometime between 1450 and 1250 BC. At that time, Egypt was probably the strongest military and cultural power in the world.

During Egypt's 18th Dynasty (1550–1295 BC), the pharaohs built a large empire outside Egypt. Their rule stretched north along the coast of Canaan and south along the Nile River. This growth in power led to large building projects throughout the land.

As the royal family became more powerful, the god Amon-Re also became more important. Egypt worshiped many gods, but devotion to Amon-Re became greater than devotion to the other gods.

It was during this time that the Israelites left Egypt. God did not rescue his people when Egypt was weak. He brought them out when Egypt was strongest.

Summary

The word exodus comes from the Greek word *exodos*, which means “the way out.” Exodus 1–15 tells how the Hebrews escaped from slavery in Egypt. The rest of Exodus (chapters 16–40) explains that the people needed more than freedom from slavery. They also needed freedom from sin and a way to live in fellowship with God.

Exodus addresses Israel's great needs:

- freedom from slavery (chapters 1–15),
- knowledge of God through the covenant (binding agreement) at Mount Sinai (chapters 16–24), and
- fellowship with God through the tabernacle, the sacred tent where God's presence rested among his people (chapters 25–40).

People today still have these same needs. We need freedom, knowledge of God, and life with him.

Author

Traditionally, Moses is believed to have written the Pentateuch (Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy). However, many modern scholars question this view. See Genesis Book Introduction, “Author.”

The Date of the Exodus

The date of Israel's departure from Egypt is important for understanding early Israelite history. The Bible focuses more on the meaning of events than on giving exact dates, so it is difficult to know the precise year of the Exodus.

Several clues help scholars estimate the date:

1. According to 1 Kings 14:25–26, Pharaoh Shishak attacked Judah during the fifth year of King Rehoboam's reign. Historical records outside the Bible date this event to 926 BC. Scholars work backward from this known date to estimate earlier events, including the exodus.
2. A second clue is the “new king” in (Exodus 1:8) who “knew nothing about Joseph.” This probably refers to the beginning of a new royal family line, or dynasty.

In the 1700s BC, groups from Asia moved into Egypt. One group, called the Hyksos, gained control of Lower Egypt around 1648 BC. Joseph and Jacob probably entered Egypt shortly before or during this period (Genesis 39; 46). The Hyksos ruled until Pharaoh Ahmose forced them out around 1540 BC. Ahmose and the kings after him were probably the rulers described in Exodus 1:8.

1. The Merneptah Stela, an Egyptian monument from about 1209 BC, mentions a conflict with Israel in southern Canaan. This is the earliest clear mention of Israel outside the Bible.

These clues have led scholars to suggest two main dates for the exodus: an early date around 1446 BC and a later date around 1270 BC.

Early Date (about 1446 BC)

The traditional view places the Exodus around 1446 BC. According to 1 Kings 6:1, King Solomon began building the temple in 967 BC, which was 480 years after the exodus. If the 480 years are understood as normal calendar years, then the exodus happened around 1446 BC. Israel would then have entered Canaan around 1406 BC.

Archaeologists have also discovered the Amarna letters. These are letters from Canaanite rulers asking Pharaoh Akhenaten for help against attackers. Some

scholars think these attackers may have been the Israelites. If true, this would support the earlier date.

Around 1100 BC, Jephthah said that Israel had lived in the promised land for 300 years (see Judges 11:26; compare Numbers 21:21–35). This also fits the earlier date.

For these reasons, many scholars have accepted a date near 1446 BC.

Late Date (about 1270 BC)

The later view places the exodus around 1270 BC, about 300 years before Solomon dedicated the temple in 967 BC. This date would place the exodus early in the reign of Pharaoh Rameses II (1279–1213 BC).

Exodus 1:11 says the Israelites helped build the city of Rameses. The city was named after this pharaoh, and archaeologists have found evidence of major building activity there during the early 1200s BC.

Some archaeologists working in Canaan between World War I and World War II reported that they could not find evidence for an Israelite conquest in the early 1300s BC, which the earlier date would require. However, they did report evidence of destruction and increased settlement activity during the late 1200s BC.

If these findings are correct and connected to Israel, they would support a date around 1270 BC for the exodus.

Those who support the later date also argue that the number 480 in 1 Kings 6:1 is symbolic rather than exact. They understand it as representing 12 generations of 40 years each. If so, the actual time between the exodus and the building of the temple may have been closer to 300 years, based on a generation length of about 25 years.

Dates for the Patriarchs

Genesis gives the ages of Israel's patriarchs, from Abraham to Joseph, but it does not give exact calendar dates for their lives.

The patriarchs (Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob) were powerful family leaders who moved from place to place. Unlike kings who ruled large empires, they did not build palaces or keep official records in libraries. Also, the climate in Canaan was not good for preserving written documents.

Because of this, the date of the exodus is important for estimating the dates of the patriarchs. Scholars also use information about the ages of the patriarchs. Passages such as Genesis 12:4, 21:5, 25:26, and 47:9

suggest that the patriarchs spent about 215 years in Canaan.

Another important question is how long Israel stayed in Egypt. Different ancient texts give different answers.

The Hebrew Masoretic Text of Exodus 12:40 says that Israel lived in Egypt for 430 years, from the time Jacob entered Egypt until the Exodus. However, the Greek Septuagint (an early translation of the Old Testament) and the Samaritan Pentateuch both say that the 430 years included Israel's time in both Canaan and Egypt. Paul also seems to follow this understanding in Galatians 3:17.

If this second view is correct, Israel would have spent about 215 years in Egypt.

Other passages, such as Genesis 15:13–16; Exodus 6:16–20; Numbers 3:17–19; 26:58–59; 1 Chronicles 6:1–3; and Acts 7:6, could support the reading of either the Hebrew or the Greek text.

It is difficult to fit all the evidence together with complete certainty. The biblical writers were not trying to provide a full chronological timeline. Even so, Israel's historical records match well with records from neighboring cultures.

Meaning and Message

The opening chapters of Genesis describe a serious problem. God created the world and human beings for blessing (Genesis 1:27–28). But sin brought a curse into the world. Human beings became deeply corrupt (6:5). People were separated from God, their Creator (3:23–24) and from one another (4:14). Death, violence, and confusion spread throughout the earth (4:8, 23–24; 11:9).

Was there any way for people to return to the blessing God originally intended?

Genesis 12–50 begins to answer that question. God chose Abraham and his descendants to live in a special covenant relationship (binding agreement) with him. God promised to make them into a great nation and to bless the whole world through them (12:1–3). Abraham trusted God even though his wife could not have children (15:6). God soon began to fulfill his promises (21:1–7).

At the beginning of the book of Exodus, however, God's promises to Abraham seemed uncertain. Abraham's descendants had become numerous, but they were now slaves in Egypt. Pharaoh, the most powerful ruler in the world, wanted to keep them under his control.

The promised land also still seemed far away. Abraham and his descendants had not owned any of the land except for a burial place (Genesis 23). How could a nation of slaves inherit the land and become a blessing to the world? Could God still keep his promises? Did he truly care about his people and know their suffering?

Exodus answers these questions by showing us who God is.

God knows the suffering of his people, and he values them. The Lord is greater than all other gods (Exodus 18:11). Exodus reveals God as the highest being in existence (3:5–6, 14–15; 6:3). He is greater than human rulers who claim to be gods and greater than the powers of nature. He alone is the true God.

The Israelites had lived in Egypt for about 400 years and had absorbed many false beliefs about gods and worship. They now needed to learn the truth again. There are not many gods. There is only one God.

God is separate from the world because he created it. He cannot be controlled by magic. The world is not ruled by equal forces of good and evil struggling against each other. God is holy (completely pure and set apart), morally perfect, faithful to his people, and eager to do good for them (Exodus 34:5–6).

God used the covenant at Sinai (Exodus 19–23) to teach his people who he is and how they should live in relationship with him.

The covenant also teaches that true worship includes ethical living. In much of the ancient world, religion and ethics were often separated. In God's covenant, however, many commands focus on how people treat one another (see 20:3–17). Those who are in a covenant relationship with God must treat one another in a just and right way.

God rescues his people and calls us into a life of holiness in order that we may have a living, personal relationship with him. The sections about the tabernacle are central to the message of Exodus (Exodus 25–40). God did not only want to bring his people into the promised land. He wanted them to live safely in his holy presence, and this became possible in (Exodus 40:34–38).

Salvation is more than forgiveness of sins. God rescues people from the slavery of sin so they may live each day in the glory of his presence and show his holy character to the world.